Thomas Hazell

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Education

DPhil (PhD) in Politics 2024 –
Department of Politics and International Relations, University of Oxford

Funded by an Economic and Social Research Council Studentship. Supervised by Dr Katerina Tertytchnaya.

Visiting Graduate Student March – April 2026
Department of Political Science and International Relations, Nazarbayev University, Astana

MPhil in Politics (Comparative Government) 2022 – 2024
Department of Politics and International Relations, University of Oxford

Grade: *Distinction*. Funded by an Economic and Social Research Council Studentship. Thesis: 'Subnational governance, patronage, and political careers in Kazakhstan,' supervised by Dr Katerina Tertytchnaya.

BA in Philosophy, Politics, and Economics 2019 – 2022
Lincoln College, University of Oxford

Grade: *First Class*. Finals examinations in politics and economics. Thesis: 'Changing the rules of autocracy: the politics of electoral reform in competitive authoritarian Ukraine,' supervised by Dr Jody LaPorte.

Work-in-Progress

For abstracts, see https://t-hazell.github.io/research.html.

Thesis papers

'Shuffling to co-opt: Subnational governance, co-optation, and political careers in Kazakhstan'. *Working paper*.

'Personnel appointments in authoritarian bureaucracies'. *Working paper*.

'Social connections and the quality of public procurement'. *In progress*.

Other work

'Which merits matter? Political performance, economic meritocracy, and elite loyalty in authoritarian states'. *Working paper*.

‘The governance effects of local elections in autocracies’. With Kirill Melnikov and Eleonora Minaeva. *Working paper*.

‘Local elections and elite management in authoritarian regimes: evidence from Kazakhstan’. With Eleonora Minaeva and Kirill Melnikov. *Working paper*.

‘Shortcuts, effort, and constituency service in an authoritarian parliament: evidence from detecting LLM use by Kazakhstan’s deputies.’ *Preliminary analysis*.

‘A “dead parliament” theory? Generative AI usage in parliamentary questions and ministerial replies in Poland’. With Thomas Brailey. *Preliminary analysis*.

Invited Talks

‘Personnel appointments in authoritarian bureaucracies.’ 20 March 2026. Department of Political Science and International Relations, Nazarbayev University, Astana.

Conferences & Workshops

‘Personnel appointments in authoritarian bureaucracies.’ *American Political Science Association Annual Meeting (APSA)*. 5 September 2026. Boston.

‘Elite Selection and Governance in Autocracies: Kazakhstan’s Natural Experiment.’ (With Kirill Melnikov and Eleonora Minaeva.) *American Political Science Association Annual Meeting (APSA)*. 4 September 2026. Boston.

‘Personnel appointments in authoritarian bureaucracies.’ *Conference of the European Political Science Society (EPSS)*. 18 June 2026. Belfast.

‘Personnel appointments in authoritarian bureaucracies.’ *4th APSG Conference on Authoritarian Politics*. 16 June 2026. Authoritarian Political Systems Group, King’s College London.

‘Which merits matter? Political performance, economic meritocracy, and elite loyalty in authoritarian states.’ *Conference of the European Political Science Association (EPSA)*. 27 June 2025. UC3M, Madrid.

‘Personnel appointments in authoritarian bureaucracies.’ *3rd APSG Conference on Authoritarian Politics*. 23 June 2025. Authoritarian Political Systems Group, King’s College London.

‘Personnel appointments in authoritarian bureaucracies.’ *3rd Conference “New Advances in the Political Economy of Development in Eurasia.”* 6 June 2025. Almaty Management University, Almaty.

'Local Elections and Elite Management in Authoritarian Regimes: Evidence from Kazakhstan.' (With Eleonora Minaeva and Kirill Melnikov, presented by Eleonora Minaeva.) *Conference of the Midwestern Political Science Association (MPSA)*. 5 April 2025. Chicago.

'Shuffling to co-opt: Subnational governance, patronage, and political careers in Kazakhstan.' *Conference of the Midwestern Political Science Association (MPSA)*. 5 April 2025. Chicago.

'Shuffling to co-opt: Subnational governance, patronage, and political careers in Kazakhstan.' *ESRC Grand Union DTP Annual Conference*. 4 June 2024. University of Oxford, Oxford.

'Shuffling to co-opt: Subnational governance, patronage, and political careers in Kazakhstan.' *Emerging Scholars Workshop on the Study of Challenges in Eurasian Politics and Society*. 24 May 2024. Center for Slavic, Eurasian, and East European Studies, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill. Presented Online.

Teaching

Undergraduate Tutor (Sole instructor for weekly small-group teaching)
University of Oxford

Tutoring of undergraduates and visiting students from Brasenose, St Edmund Hall, and Regent's Park colleges in the following courses:

Comparative Government (Final exams core paper). TT (Summer) 2026, MT (Autumn) 2026.

Politics in Russia and the Former Soviet Union (Final exams options paper). MT (Autumn) 2025, TT (Summer) 2026.

Professional & Research Experience

Research Assistant on Non-Violent Repression in Electoral Autocracies
September 2024 – present
Department of Politics and International Relations, University of Oxford

Research assistance to Dr Katerina Tertytchnaya's ESRC-funded project on administrative and bureaucratic repression with an empirical focus on the Russian Federation. Including text-as-data/classification, survey data, and event data tasks.

Election Observer (Short-term), Uzbekistan October 2024
OSCE ODIHR Election Observation Mission

UK-seconded short-term observer for the OSCE ODIHR mission in Samarqand region during the 2024 parliamentary elections.

Consultant Researcher June – October 2024
Ridgeway Information, London

Consultancy supporting the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA)'s nuclear non-proliferation work. Open source methods and Russian-language support, especially on projects related to the former Soviet Union.

Research Assistant on AUTHLIB (PI: Stephen Whitefield) September 2023 – January 2024
Department of Politics and International Relations, University of Oxford

Part of the joint UKRI/Horizon Europe funded project 'neo-authoritarianisms in Europe and the liberal democratic response' (https://www.authlib.eu/), led at Oxford by Stephen Whitefield, Spyros Kosmidis, and Zofia Stemplowska. Coding tweets from European political parties for NLP training.

Research Assistant to Dr Lenka Buštíková May – September 2023
Oxford School of Global and Area Studies, University of Oxford

Data collection for projects on illiberalism and irregular armed groups' political role in Ukraine.

Research Assistant on the Oxford University Economic Recovery Project February – November 2021
Smith School of Enterprise and the Environment, University of Oxford

Research assistance, using government and media sources to track state spending in response to Covid-19.

Intern Summer 2021
Oxford Internet Institute, University of Oxford

Service

Reviewer for *Journal of Elections, Public Opinion and Parties* and *Communist and Post-Communist Studies*.

Selected Scholarships & Awards

Grand Union Doctoral Training Partnership Studentship, Economic and Social Research Council, 2022–2026.

Competitively awarded doctoral studentship, covering fees and stipend for the MPhil in Politics followed by the DPhil (PhD) in Politics, both at Oxford. Value: ≈ £145,000.

Pangram research collaboration, Pangram Labs, New York City, 2026.

Credits for LLM detection software. Value: $5,000.

Tatham Exhibition and College Scholarship, Lincoln College, University of Oxford, 2020–2022.

Awarded for academic performance. Value: £450.

Languages

English (Native). Russian (Intermediate). Qazaq (Beginner).

Computer Skills

R (Advanced): Modelling & causal inference methods. Survey data. Visualisation. Managing large datasets. Web scraping/automation. Quarto. Machine learning (`tidymodels`). GIS (`sf`).

Python: Scraping. Data management. Natural language processing/ text-as-data/machine learning, including `torch`. GIS.

Other: OpenAI APIs (Batch, Fine Tuning). Git/GitHub. Cloud computing (Azure, Google Cloud). Databases/basic SQL. LaTeX.

Additional Training

Qazaq language, Faculty of Asian and Middle Eastern Studies, University of Oxford, November 2025–February 2026.

Comprehensive E-learning Course for OSCE/ODIHR Observers, September 2024.

Fieldwork Safety Overseas, University of Oxford Safety Office, June 2023.

Advanced R for the Social Sciences, Social Sciences Division, University of Oxford, February 2023.

International Experience

Intensive Russian language training in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, Summer 2022.

Travel in Kyrgyzstan, Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, Azerbaijan, Georgia, Armenia.

References

Dr Jody LaPorte
Gonticas Fellow in Politics and International Relations
Lincoln College
University of Oxford
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Dr Katerina Tertytchnaya
Associate Professor of Comparative Politics
Department of Politics and International Relations
University of Oxford
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